
ssl-mgr

Release 7.3.0

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SSL-MGR

Certificate management tool.

Note that the *Docs* directory contains the full PDF which includes details of the most recent changes (*Docs/Changes-7.x.rst*).

1.1 Key Features

- Handles creating new and renewing certificates
- Generates key pairs and Certificate Signing Request (CSR) to provide maximum control
- Supports http-01 and dns-01 acme challenges
- Outputs DNS files for acme DNS-01 authentication as well as optional DANE TLSA files. These files are to be included by the apex domain zone file. This makes updates straightforward.
- Uses certbot in manual mode to handle communication with letsencrypt, account tracking etc.
- Processes multiple domains and each domain each can have multiple certs. For example separate web and mail certs.

1.2 Overview

By way of background, I wrote this with 3 goals. Specifically to:

- Simplify certificate management - (i.e. automatic, simple and robust)
- Support *dns-01* acme challenge with Letsencrypt (as well as *http-01*)
- Support *DANE TLS*

The aim is to make things robust, complete and as simple to use as possible. Under the hood, make it sensible and automate wherever feasible.

A good tool does things correctly while using it should be straightforward and as simple as possible; but no simpler.

In practical terms, there are only 2 common commands that are needed with *sslm-mgr*:

- **renew** - creates new certificate(s) in *next* : current certs remain in *curr*.
- **roll** - moves *next* to become the new *curr*.

Once things are set up these can be run out of cron - renew, then wait, then roll. Clean and simple.

Strictly speaking, cert rolling is only needed when they are advertized via DNS (for example) and some time is required for things to flush through.

In the first step, rolling advertized both old and new keys and keeps them available for an appropriate period of time; typically long enough for DNS info to propagate and DNS servers to update.

In the second, and last, roll step, dns is updated to advertize only the new certs.

Changing to new certs without rolling can be problematic if some DNS servers still point to the older certs.

Without any loss of generality we always renew and then roll. The roll wait time can always be set to 0 if no public keys are being advertized over DNS.

The **sslm-mgr --status** option gives a convenient summary of all managed certificates along with their expiration and time remaining time before renewal.

The separate **sslm-info** program provides a convenient way to display information about keys, certs (or chains of certs), CSRs etc.

The **sslm-verify** tool checks if a cert is valid.

N.B. DNSSEC is required for DANE otherwise it is not needed. However, we do recommend using DNSSEC and have made available the tool we use to simplify DNS/DNSSEC management¹.

DANE can use either self-signed certs or known CA signed certs. *ssl-mgr* makes it straightforward to create self-signed certs as well.

However, in practice, it is safer to use CA signed certs for SMTP to reduce the chance of potential delivery problems in the event a mail server requires a CA chain of trust.

We therefore recommend using CA signed certificates and therefore publishing DANE TLSA records using those certificates. Each MX will have its own TLSA record.

While DANE can be used for other TLS services, such as https, in practice it is only used with email.

For convenience, there is a PDF version of this document in the Docs directory.

Note:

All git tags are signed with arch@sapience.com key which is available via WKD or download from <https://www.sapience.com/tech>. Add the key to your package builder gpg keyring. The key is included in the Arch package and the source= line with *?signed* at the end can be used to verify the git tag. You can also manually verify the signature

1.3 Important Changes

Changes since version 7.1.1:

- Some code re-org and packaging switch to uv from hatch.
- New dependency: *pyconcurrent* package (was optional)

Available on [Github](#) and [AUR](#)

Version 7 brings some significant enhancements supporting Letsencrypt's upcoming short lifetime certs (45-day and 6-day) as well as *ACME profiles*.

We revisited the *when to renew* a certificate decision so that we can sensibly handle short lifetime certs.

There are new config options for those wanting to customize it. In preparation for the upcoming May 13, 2026 45-day cert availability, we request *tlsserver* profile by default.

Everything should work without change. However, there are a couple of optional config options we **recommend** removing.

Please see [Latest Changes](#) for the details and explanation of which configs should be removed if they are being used.

¹ dns_tools : https://github.com/gene-git/dns_tools

1.4 ssl-mgr: Details

More details about *ssl-mgr* tools are available in the [More Details](#) section.

LICENSE

ssl-mgr software is a certificate management tool.

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LATEST CHANGES

Note that the full PDF doc is in the Docs directory and includes the details of all current changes taken from the *Changes-7.x.rst* file.

Version 7.3.0

- Fix Typo that broke generation of DANE TLSA files.
- New tool: `sslm-tlsa-hash`
Given a cert, generate the DANE TLSA hash using internal tools and using `openssl`. Confirm they match. Once TLSA records are created, you can now double check the cert hash is correct.
- Coming soon: support for DNS-PERSIST-01 See [Letsecnrypt Blog](#) and preliminary [Draft spec](#).

Version 7.2.0

- Code Reorg
- Switch packaging from hatch to uv
- Testing to confirm all working correctly on python 3.14.2
- New dependency: `pyconcurrent` is now required instead of optional (code simplification):
Available on [Github](#) and [AUR](#)

Version 7.0.0 : (Major version with important changes)

Enhancements

These are to support upcoming Letsencrypt changes. See:

- [Letsencrypt_45](#)
- [Letsencrypt_Profiles](#)
- [Letsencrypt_Root](#)
- [Letsencrypt_Client_Auth](#)
- [Letsencrypt_Baseline](#)

3.1 ACME profiles

Letsencrypt offers (or will offer) 3 profiles:

Profile	Description
classic	the current 90-day cert (goes away at some point)
tlsserver	new 45-day certs.
shortlived	new 6-day certs.

See the Letsencrypt website for additional information.

ssl-mgr now requests the *tlsserver* profile by default. If unavailable it falls back to classic profile.

On May 13 2026, Letsencrypt will switch the *tlsserver* profile to 45-day certificates. At that time, *ssl-mgr* certs will be the 45-day certs, provided the profile has not been set to something other than *tlsserver*.

Please note that these certs will not only have half the expiration of current 90-day certs but are also dropping a few fields.

tlsserver profile certs will **not** provide:

- A *Common Name* field

CN has been *not recommended* by the Baseline Requirements for several years now.

- A *Subject Key Identifier*

A SKID is *not recommended* by the Baseline Requirements.

- A *TLS Client Auth Extended Key Usage*

root programs are moving towards requiring “single-purpose” issuance hierarchies, where every certificate has only a single EKU.

- A *Key Encipherment Key Usage* for certificates with RSA public keys

This KU was used by older RSA-based TLS cipher suites, but is unnecessary with TLS 1.3. Please note that no certificate should be using RSA at this point.

3.2 Root Certs

tlsserver and *shortlived* profiles are signed by new *Gen Y* root and intermediate certs.

See the note below about removing the **ca_preferred_chain** config option.

3.3 ca_preferred_chain option

The *ca_preferred_chain* config option, specifies a root chain preference, remains supported by *ssl-mgr*.

Stop using this CA config option the new “ISRG Root YE” root chain is available. They will be available on or before May 2026. Consult the Letsencrypt website for more information.

Until then you can:

- leave it unset (Letsencrypt will use the X1 RSA root chain)
- set it to “ISRG Root X2”

As soon as LE makes the new Gen Y root chain available, remove this setting. You could set it to “ISRG Root YE” but that will be the default with the 45-day certs that roll out on May 13 2026. After that it definitely better to let Letsencrypt determine the root chain to use, so remove the *ca_preferred_chain* option at that time.

Once Generation Y root and intermediate certs are available, letsencrypt will use them for the ACME *tlsserver* and *shortlived* profiles.

These *Gen Y* root certs replace the older X2 (EC) and X1 (RSA) root certs. Letsencrypt will use the *YE* root chain for EC certs and *YR* for RSA certs. We recommend only using EC certs today (no more RSA).

With the older 90-day *classic* profile, it was reasonable to prefer the X2 root chain for EC certs since the default was (and still as of writing this note) to use X1 (RSA).

3.4 ca_preferred_acme_profile option

A new option in CA config file, *conf.d/ca-info.conf*. Each CA item can now set the preferred profile. For example it may be useful to have a second Letsencrypt item using a different acme profile or maybe a different validation mechanism (like dns-01 vs http-01).

- Can be set to one of the available ACME profiles.
- Since classic will go away, the choice is between *tlsserver* and *shortlived*
- Defaults to *tlsserver* if not provided in the config.

In the short term, if really needed for some reason, you can request the *classic* profile. But, at some point, this profile will no longer be supported by Letsencrypt.

3.5 Renew Timing

The enhanced decision on when renew is based the certificate's original lifetime.

In order to handle shorter certificates we added fine grained control over when a cert should be renewed based on the original certificate expiration.

See *Config ssl-mgr.conf* for more detail about the new *[renew_info]* section that replaces the 2 older variables: *renew_expire_days* and *renew_expire_days_spread*.

Example files have also been updated as well.

Please note that existing configs will continue to work (as usual). Any older variables will apply to 90+ day cert renewals if they are not already set in the new *[renew_info]* section.

The defaults provide reasonable choices even for very short lived certs. Simply **remove** (or comment out) the 2 options in the *[globals]* section:

- **renew_expire_days**
- **renew_expire_days_spread**

If you're happy with the defaults, the *[renew_info]* section is completely optional.

3.6 Cert Information

Certificate information reported by *sslm-mgr -s* and *sslm-info* now includes the lifetime. e.g. 45-day or 90-day.

3.7 License

ssl-mgr now licensed under GPL-2.0-or-later.

MORE DETAILS

The tool keeps and manages 2 versions of every set of data. Each set of data is comprised of certificates, keys, CSRs, etc. One version of the data has the current (aka *curr*) set and the other has the next set (aka *next*). *curr* are those currently in use while *next* are those that are on deck to become the next current set.

Key rolling is standard practice and should be familiar to those who have implemented *DNSSEC*. A *roll* is a robust method of updating keys/certs with new ones in a way that ensures nothing breaks.

The current key/cert is always advertised in DNS. After creating new keys/certs, DNS is then updated to advertise both the current and the newly created next ones.

An appropriate amount of time needs to pass with both current and next in DNS before doing the *roll*. This gives the time needed for DNS servers to refresh. Once refreshed, the DNS servers now have both the current and the next set of keys/certs.

After sufficient time, update a second time, and now only the new keys (the new current ones) are advertised in DNS.

A *roll* is required for *DNSSEC* as well as for *DANE*, which we manage.

Without any loss of functionality and to keep things nice and simple, we treat every update as requiring a key roll.

Again, a *roll* is required for *DANE TLS* but is not needed for things such as web server certificate update.

If you are not advertizing certificate info using DNS servers (e.g. *DNSSEC*, *DANE*) then there is no need have any delay between making a new certificate using *-renew* and doing the *-roll*.

In this case, you can set the config variable *min_roll_mins* to **0** minutes. The default min roll time is 90 minutes. And if automating (via cron or similar) then you can also use a smaller do the *roll* immediately after the *renew* as well. In cron you could have roll set to run 1 minutes after the renew.

Furthermore, you are always in control and, should it be needed, you can do whatever you choose.

e.g. Using *-f* will force things to happen (a roll or create new certs and so on.)

4.1 Curr & Next

These are kept in directories that contain different versions of the same set of files. Of course *next* has newer versions. For example for the group *example.com* and the service *web-ec* these directories would be located in:

```
certs/example.com/web-rc/curr/  
certs/example.com/web-rc/next/
```

In order of creation these are:

File	What
privkey.pem	the private key
csr.pem	certificate signing request
cert.pem	certificate
chain.pem	CA root + intermediate certs
fullchain.pem	Our cert.pem + CA chain
bundle.pem	Our privkey + fullchain
info	Contains date/time when next was rolled to curr (curr only)

Once config is setup, a cron/timer to run *renew* followed by *roll* 2 or 3 hours later should take care of everything. Can be run daily or weekly.

The *curr/next* directories will also be copied to the production directory, as specified in *conf.d/ssl-mgr.conf* by the variable *prod_cert_dir*.

4.2 Diffie-Hellman Parameters

There is also a tool, *sslm-dhparm*, which generates Diffie-Hellman parameters. This can be added to the cron file.

By default *sslm-dhparm* only generates new parameters if they are more than 120 days old, or absent. This can therefore be run weekly without issues.

Note: The new, preferred and now default DH parameters are based on the [rfc_7919](#) pre-defined named groups. The default is *ffdhe4096*. Pre-defined named groups only need to be generated once and will only be generated if absent.

Strictly these don't need to be in cron, but its convenient to have the program check and create DH parameters should the file be missing. May happen occasionally after adding new domain.

The 6 month default refresh, only applies for non RFC-7919 params, and is recommended because it can be a bit time consuming to generate them. Actual time varies with key size.

When using a pre-defined named group (e.g. *ffdhe4096*), it is very quick to produce and tool simply checks if file exists without any age requirement. These are only created once.

Sample cron files are provided in the examples directory.

4.3 Additional Info

There are several additional commands that offer fine grained control, in case its needed. These are discussed in detail below. One example is the *-f* or *-force* option which does what the name suggests.

The tool handles keys, certificate signing requests (CSR) and certs. It also takes care of generating DANE TLSA DNS records should you want to use them and reloads/restarts specific servers whenever they need it. Each server has defined dependencies which trigger restarts whenever those dependencies have changed.

For example, a web server may depend on one or more apex domain certificates and will be restarted when any of those certs change.

It needs external support tools such as zone signing for DNSSEC and restarting dns servers as well as reloading web or mail servers to ensure new certs are picked up. These are provided via the top level config file.

There is support for private/self-signed CAs and Letsencrypt CA. Letsencrypt acme validation challenges¹ can use either http or dns; dns is preferred whenever possible.

¹ acme-challenge : <https://letsencrypt.org/docs/challenge-types/>

4.4 DANE

For DANE TLSA records, care must be taken to properly *roll* new keys. Key rolling ensures that the *next* key and the *curr* key are both advertised in DNS for some period. After some time the new key can be made *curr*. This waiting period should be long enough to provide sufficient time for all DNS servers to pick up both old and new new keys before DNS is changed to only show the new ones. It's reasonable to wait 2 x the DNS TTL or longer.

After that wait time, the new (*next*) keys can be then be made available as the new *curr* ones. Applications, mail really, can now use the new keys since the world has both sets of keys.

Then DNS servers can then be updated again, this time with just the new (now *curr*) keys in the TLSA records. DANE key roll is similar to key roll for DNSSEC. DANE TLSA actually requires DNSSEC.

DANE was designed as an alternative to third party certificate authorities like letsencrypt which means its fine to used self signed or CA signed certs. While DANE could be used for web servers to date it is really only used for email.

The companion *dns_tools* package takes care of all our DNSSEC needs²:

And I recommend using it to simplify the DNS refresh needed for validating Letsencrypt acme challenges using *DNS-01* as well as for DANE TLSA. A DNS refresh means resign zones (when using DNSSEC) and then restarting the primary dns server.

DANE TLSA records contain the public key, or a hash of that key, and thus need to be refreshed whenever that key changes; this is the key roll. It also means that if the key is kept the same, then the TLSA records aren't changing³. *ssl-mgr* has an option to re-use the public key when certs are being renewed, and this allows the TLSA records to remain unchanged. In that case no key roll is needed until that key is changed. Some may find this useful.

It basically means using the same certificate signing request, CSR, to get a new cert. The CSR contains the public key associated with the private key. So if keys dont change CSR doesn't change either, and the same CSR can be re-used.

However, I find *ssl-mgr* makes it so simple to renew with new keys, that I don't see much point in reusing the old keys. Of course using new keys offers a security benefit.

Note that each MX for the mail domain will have a TLSA record as required by the standard.

4.5 Acme Challenge

Using *DNS-01* to validate Letsencrypt acme challenges is done by adding the challenge TXT records to DNS, signing the zones (if using DNSSEC) and pushing them out, so that Letsencrypt can subsequently check those DNS records match appropriately and then they provide the requested cert. Some tool to do that DNS refresh is needed for this pupose. I use *dns_tools* to do that. DNS refresh also happens after DANE TLSA records are updated.

This should run on the DNS signing server. This allows files with DNS records, acme challenges and TLSA, to be written to accessible directories on same machine. I may enhance this to allow the dns signing server to be remote, some day.

² *dns_tools* : https://github.com/gene-git/dns_tools

³ DANE can use either public key or the cert. Cert does change when it's renewed even if the public key is unchanged. I believe pretty much everyone uses the public key not the cert in TLSA reords.

GETTING STARTED

The first order of business is creating the config files. These specify everything that's needed.

This includes the shared config *ssl-mgr.conf* which includes the commands to restart servers (web, mail), where to put the acme challenge files (web or dns) and where the final certificates are to be stored.

Each certificate to be issued has it's own *service* config file.

The sample configs provided in *examples/conf.d* provide a template to get started.

5.1 Tools

The main tool for generating and managing certificates is *ssl-mgr*. As usual, help is available using *-h*.

There is also a dev mode, providing access to some lower lever tasks. You probably should seldom, if ever, need dev mode, but in case you do, it is activated by using the *dev* command as the first argument.

For example help would be done using

```
ssl-mgr dev -h
```

The tools provided :

Tool	Purpose
ssl-m-auth-hook	internal - used with certbot's manual hook option
ssl-m-dhparm	generate Diffie Hellman paramater file(s)
ssl-m-info	display info about cert.pem, csr.pem, chain.pem, privkey.pem, etc
ssl-m-mgr	primary tool for certificate management
ssl-m-verify	verifies any cert.pem file using public key from chain.pem

5.2 Groups & Services

To help organize all the data we have groups and services.

What are groups? There are only two kinds of groups: Certificate Authorities and Apex Domains. CA can be external Certificate Authority or internal.

Internal certs includes self-signed (root) certs and local intermediate certs that are signed by an internal (self-signed) root cert.

5.2.1 Groups

Certificate Authorities

The job needed from a CA is to take a CSR and return a signed cert.

- Internal CA
 - Self-signed root certs are used only to sign local intermediate certs.
 - Local intermediate certs are used to sign certs. The intermediates are signed by a local self signed root.

Using internal certs are a good starting point when getting set up and exploring *ssl-mgr*.

- Letsencrypt CA

When ready, using their test server, which is more generous with limits, is a good way to prepare for the production. LE's test server is invoked by using the *-t* option. The *-dry-run* option may be helpful too.

When all is working as desired, drop the test option and you're ready to go into production.

Apex Domains

An Apex domain is the *main* part of the domain that has it's own DNS authority.

If *example.com* has a DNS SOA record, then it would be the apex domain and any subdomain, such as *foo.example.com* would be a part of that apex domain. So, whenever we deal with DNS, we always deal with the apex domain.

Each apex domain is a *group* and may have 1 or more certificates where each certificate is associated with 1 service.

Services

Each service gets 1 certificate.

An apex domain may want/need different certs for different services. Each service has one certificate.

An apex domain, for example, may have a mail service and a web service. Each of these has it's own unique cert. Now, mail may use 2 certs, elliptic curve and RSA, then we would simply have 2 services for mail. In this case lets call them *mail-ec* and *mail-rsa* and lets call the web service *web-ec*. Its good to name services in a way thats useful for administrator - it has no significance to the code other than the name must be a good filename so cannot contain / etc.

In the same vein, for self signed CA certs, we have 2 items - a *root* cert and an *intermediate* cert where each belongs to the special group *ca*. Again, each of these is a separate service.

Since each service has its own certificate, each has its own X509 name which describe what it is. This includes things like Common Name, Alternative Names and organization. In this case it includes info about the keys to be used and which entity is provides the signed certificate.

Each service has it's information provided by a service file. It has all the information needed to create keys and CSRs as well as certs. This include key type, various *name* fields along with which CA should be used. The *name* fields are essentially *x509 Name*⁴ fields. These include things like Common Name, Organization and so on.

CSR (certificate signing request) contains the *subject* organization (thats the apex domain org) information along with the public key. The private key is kept in a separate file. The CSR is sent to the CA which, all being well, returns a (signed) certificate.

The resulting cert and certificate chain(s) are kept together with the key and CSR files. A cert is signed by the *Issuer* and in addition to the signature contains the public key. The *chain* file contains the public key and x509 Name of the certificate issuer.

There are a couple of tools provided (*sslm-verify* and *sslm-info*) that make it easy to validate a certificate or display information about it. *sslm-info* works on all the *sslm-mgr* outputs : keys, csrs, certs, chains, fullchains and bundles.

⁴ x509 Name <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/X.509>

5.3 Key/Cert Files

- CSR (certificate signing request)

Each certificate is generated from its CSR which contains the public key. Public key is generated from the private key so there is no need to save a public key.

A CSR is always used to make a cert. This provides control as well as consistency across CAs, be they self or other. The public key is in the CSR and also in the certificate provided and signed by the CA. We support both RSA and Elliptic Curve (EC) keys. EC is strongly preferred. In fact, while RSA keys are still used they are only needed by ancient client software for browsers and email. That said, RSA is still in common use for DKIM⁵ signing for some reason. We DKIM sign outbound mail with both RSA and EC.

- Cert

Each cert contains the public key which is signed by the CA. It carries the *subject* apex domain name along with 'subject alternative names' or SANS. SANS allow a certificate to contain multiple domain or subdomain names. The *issuer*, which signed the certificate, has its name in the cert as well. Name in this context is an X509 name meaning, common name, organization, organization unit and so on.

- Certificate chains

- **chain** = CA root cert + Signing CA cert

Signing CA cert is usually the CA Intermediate cert(s) Note that the root cert may or may not be included by CAs other than LE For those client chain = signing ca

- **fullchain** = Domain cert + chain

- **bundle** = priv-key + fullchain.

A bundle is just a chain made of the private key plus the fullchain. This is preferred by postfix⁶.

- Private key

Also called simply the *key*. It is stored in a file with restricted permissions. The companion public key can be generated from the private key. By always generating the public key from the private key, they are guaranteed to remain consistent.

Key, CSR and certificate files are stored in the convenient PEM format. Certificates use X509.V3⁷ which provides for *extensions* such as SANS which are critical to have. CSR files use *PKCS#10*⁸ which can carry the same set of X509 extensions.

5.4 Tool Commands

As mentioned above, once things are set up for your use case, then all that's needed is periodically run

```
sslm-mgr -renew
```

which will check get new certs, if it's time to renew. A couple of hours later make those certs live by doing:

```
sslm-mgr -roll
```

⁵ DKIM -> <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc6376>

⁶ Postfix TLS -> https://www.postfix.org/postconf.5.html#smtpd_tls_chain_files

⁷ X509 V3 -> <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc5280>

⁸ PKCS#10 CSR -> <https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc2986>

5.4.1 sslm-mgr

Has 2 modes - a *regular* mode and a developer or *dev* mode. In either case, the groups and services are read from the *ssl-mgr* config file. The config file values *can* be overridden from the command line.

To specify a group and service(s) on the command line use the format:

```
... <group-name>:<service_1>,<service_2>,...
```

For example, for a domain with multiple services, you can limit to one or two services using:

```
sslm-mgr -s example.com:mail-ec
sslm-mgr -s example.com:mail-ec,mail-rsa
```

Help command for *sslm-mgr* :

```
sslm-mgr -h
usage: /usr/bin/sslm-mgr [-h] [-v] [-f] [-r] [-d] [-t] [-n] [-s] [-renew] [-roll]
                        [-roll-mins MIN_ROLL_MINS] [-dns] [-clean-keep CLEAN_KEEP] [-clean-all]
                        [grps_svcs ...]

SSL Manager

positional arguments:
grps_svcs                List groups/services: grp1:[sv1, sv2,...] grp2:[ALL] ...
                        (default: from config)

options:
-h, --help                show this help message and exit
-v, --verb                More verbose output
-f, --force                Forces on for renew / roll regardless if too soon
-r, --reuse                Reuse curr key with renew. tlsa unchanged if using
                        selector=1 (pubkey)
-d, --debug                debug mode : print dont do
-t, --test                Letsencrypt --test-cert
-n, --dry-run              Letsencrypt --dry-run
-s, --status                Display cert status. With --verb shows more info
-renew, --renew            Renew keys/csr/cert keep in next (config renew_expire_days)
-roll, --roll              Roll Phase : Make next new curr, copy to production,
                        refresh dns if needed
-roll-mins MIN_ROLL_MINS, --min-roll-mins MIN_ROLL_MINS
                        Only roll if next is older than this (config min_roll_mins)
-dns, --dns-refresh        dns: Use script to sign zones & restart primary
                        (config dns.restart_tool)
-clean-keep CLEAN_KEEP, --clean-keep CLEAN_KEEP
                        Clean database dirs keeping newest N (see --clean-all)
-clean-all, --clean-all
                        Clean up all grps/svcs not just active domains

For dev options add "dev" as 1st argument
```

When more control is needed then *dev* mode offers above commands plus few more options. To see developer help:

```
# sslm-mgr dev -h
usage: /usr/bin/sslm-mgr ... [-keys] [-csr] [-cert] [-copy] [-ntoc] [-certs-prod]
```

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```
[grps_svcs ...]

SSL Manager Dev Mode

positional arguments:
grps_svcs              List groups/services: grp1:[sv1, sv2,...] grp2:[ALL] ...
                        (default: see config)

options:
... same as above plus:
-cert, --new-cert      Make new next/cert
-certs-prod, --certs-to-prod
                        Copy keys/certs : (mail, web, tlsa, etc)
-copy, --copy-csr      Copy curr key to next (used by --reuse)
-csr, --new-csr        Make next CSR
-fsr, --force-server-restarts Forces server restarts even if not needed
-keys, --new-keys      Make next new keys
-ntoc, --next-to-curr  Move next to curr

For standard options drop "dev" as 1st argument
```

5.5 Config Files

Sample configs are show in Appendix [Appendix](#) and the files themselves are provided in *examples/conf.d* directory.

When first setting up its a good idea to start with creating a self signed CA and use that. When you're ready then change the signing CA to letsencrypt in the service file and run with the LE test-cert server by using

```
sslm-mgr --test
```

You may also use the letsencrypt *--dry-run* option.

Once that is working for you then you use the normal LE server by dropping the test option.

Config files are located in *conf.d*. There are 2 shared configs and one config for each group/service. Service configs files resides under their *group* directory.

The common configs are *ssl-mgr.conf* and *ca-info.conf* and are used for all groups and services.

ssl-mgr.conf is the main config file and we'll go over it in detail below. It includes the list of domains and their services. If it's needed, the tool can also take 1 or more groups and services on the command line.

ca-info.conf is a list of available CAs. Each CA name can be referenced in service configs to request that CA to provide the certificate.

As described earlier, there are 2 kinds of groups: *CA* and *Domain* groups. The *CA* group is for self created CAs while *domain* are named by the apex domain. Each group item has 1 or more *services*.

Each service gets it's own certificate. Typically services are named for the purpose they are used for (mail, web etc) but also for any characteristics of the certificate, such key type (RSA, Elliptic Curve) and sometimes by the CA as well.

Each (*group*, *service*) pair is described by it's own config located in the file:

```
conf.d/<group>/<service>
```

This file describes the organization and details for one service. This includes Which CA is to sign the certificate as well as any DANE TLS⁹ info needed to generate TLSA records.

N.B. Each service is to be signed by the designated CA.

If you want 2 certs signed by 2 different CAs, e.g. both self and letsencrypt, then each would have it's own separate service and associated config file.

E.g. mail-self and mail-le. For each domain, the TLSA records for all services are aggregated into a single file, tlsa.rr to be included by the DNS server.

N.B.

letsencrypt signing the same CSR counts towards their limits independent of validation method used (http-01 or dns-01).

5.5.1 Service Config

Info for each service to create it's cert. Each domain may have separate certs for different services (mail, web, etc). Each service must therefore have it's own unique config file. Its good practice to use separate certs for each different use cases, to help mitigate any impact of key related security issues.

Each config provides:

- Organization info (CN, O, OU, SAN_Names, ...)
- name, org, service (mail, web etc)
- Which CA should will be requested to sign this cert + validation method). Self signed dont need a validation method. + Letsencrypt, for example, allows http-01 and dns-01 as validation methods.
- DANE TLS info - list of (port, usage, selector, match) - e.g. (25,3,1,1)
- Key type for the public/private key pair

5.6 Output

All generated data is keyy in a dated directory under the *db* dir and links are provided for *curr* and *next*

- curr -> db/<date-time>
- next -> db/<date-time>
- prev -> db/<date-time>

After a cert has been successful generated, each dir will contain :

File	What
privkey.pem	private key
csr.pem	certificate signing request
cert.pem	certificate
chain.pem	root + intermediate CA cert
fullchain.pem	cert + chain
bundle.pem	privkey + fullchain
info	Contains date/time when next was rolled to curr (curr only)

The bundle.pem file, which has the priv key, is preferred by postfix to provide atomic update and avoid potential race during updates. That could happen if key and cert are read from separate files.

In addition there are the acme challenge files. The *ssl-mgr.conf* file is where to specify where to store these files.

⁹ TLSA <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc6698>

5.6.1 DNS-01 Validation

For dns-01 the location is specified as a directory:

```
[dns]
    acme_dir = '...'
```

The acme challenges will be saved into a file under `<acme_dir>` with apex domain name as suffix:

```
<acme_dir>/acme-challenge.<apex_domain>
```

The format of the DNS resource record is per RFC 8555¹⁰ spec. The challenge file should be included by the DNS zone file for that apex domain. Once the challenge session is complete, the file will be replaced by an empty file, which ensures that there are no errors including it in the domain zone file.

5.6.2 HTTP-01 Validation

For http-01 validation the location is specified by `server_dir` directory:

```
[web]
    server_dir = '...'
```

The individual challenge files, one per (sub)domain will be saved in a file following RFC 8555¹¹ spec:

```
<server_dir>/<apex_domain>/.well-known/acme-challenge/<token>
```

If the web server is not local then ssh will be used to deliver the file the remote server.

N.B. In all cases please ensure that the process has appropriate write permissions.

5.6.3 DANE-TLSA DNS File

If DANE is on for any service, then the TLSA records will be saved under one or more directories specified in the `[dns]` section of `ssl-mgr.conf`.

```
[dns]
    ...
    tlsa_dirs = [<tlsa_1>, <tlsa_2>, ...]
```

Each directory, `<tlsa_1>`, `<tlsa_2>` etc, will be populated with one file per apex_domain containing the TLSA records for that domain. The file will be named:

N.B. Mail server needs a TLSA record for each key/certificate is used. If, for example, postfix is set up to use either *RSA* or *EC* certs, then you **must** provide a TLSA record for both of them. And there must be record for the apex domain as well as every MX host. We determine the MX hosts via DNS lookup of the apex domain.

```
tlsa.<apex_domain>
```

Each file should be included by the DNS zone file for that apex domain.

¹⁰ DNS-01 Acme Challenge URI -> <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc8555#section-8.4>

¹¹ HTTP-01 Acme Challenge URI -> <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc8555#section-8.3>

5.7 Certbot

A few notes on certbot and how we're using it.

In addition to the database directory (*db*) there is also a *cb* dir which is provided to certbot. Certbot uses to keep letsencrypt accounts. Each group-service has its own everything - this includes it's own certbot *cb* and thus separately registered LE (Letsencrypt) account for each service.

We are using cerbot in manual mode. This gives us a lot of control and allows us to use our own generated CSR as well as to specify where the resulting cert and chain files get stored.

When sending a CSR with apex domain plus sub-domains, each (sub)domain gets a challenge and each challenge must be validated by LE before cert is issued. Challenges can be validated by acme http-01 or dns-01. Wildcard sub-domains (*.example.com) can only be validated using dns-01.

Certbot sends each challenge to a *hook* program. The *hook* program is called once per challenge. Information about the challenge and which sub-domain are passed to the *hook* program in environment variables. Env variables also tell the program how many more challenges remain to be sent. Once all the challenges have been delivered - and only after the *hook* program returns - LE will then seek to validate all of the acme challenges, whether http or dns validation is being used.

This is actually really good - it means that we can push all the challenges out - and wait for every DNS authoritative name server to have the TXT records before allowing the hook to return once it has every acme challenge.

In older versions of certbot, validation took place after each sub-domain challenge, and for DNS that meant dns refresh - wait for NS to update - LE checks and sends next challenge. This could potentially very long wait times - I read of some folks waiting many hours. Now with the new way as described above, whether DNS or HTTP challenge, it takes only seconds or minutes.

It seems to me that LE checks directly with each authoritative NS, which is the most efficient way to check - rather than waiting on some random recursive server to get updated.

5.8 TLSA Note

The service config allows DANE to be specified.

The input field takes the form of a list, one item per port:

```
dane_tls = [[25, 'tcp', 3, 1, 1], [...], ...]
```

Each item has port (25 here), the network protocol (tcp) along with *usage* (3), *selector* (1) and *hash_type* (also 1).

You should use (3,1,1).

The dane records normally contain the current TLSA records. During rollover they contain both current and next ones, and after rollover completes, and next becomes current then we're back to the normal case with only current TLSA records.

Each apex domain has it's own file of TLSA records, *tlsa.<apex_domain>*.

The *ssl-mgr.conf* DNS section also specifies where these DNS TLSA record files should be copied to - so that the DNS tools can include them in the apex domain zone file.

The best way to handle the dane resource records is by using \$INCLUDE in dns zone file to picks up *tlsa.<apex_domain>* file.

DNS server is refreshed (i.e. zone files signed and primary server is restarted) whenever a dane tlsa file changes.

The TLSA records change when the private key is updated (leading to change in the hash itself) or when the dane-info is changed (e.g. change of ports or other dane info). It certainly changes after a *renew* builds new keys/certs in *next* and after *roll* when the new *curr* is updated.

For doing rollover properly, order is important.

```
curr → curr + next → DNS
```

After 2xTTL or longer:

```
next → curr → update mail server → refresh DNS
```

ssl-mgr takes care of this.

While it is true that reusing a key, means not having to deal with key rollover as often, that only helps when doing things manually. And in fact even doing it manually, doing things less frequently may mean mistakes are more likely. There is also a small security reduction obviously in reusing a key.

When things are automated, as here with *ssl-mgr* taking care of everything, then there is little benefit to key reuse. So we support it, but we recommend just renew and roll and all will be fine :)

5.9 ssl-mgr application

5.9.1 Usage

To run - go to terminal and use :

```
ssl-mgr --help
```

5.9.2 Configuration

The configuration file for *ssl-mgr* is chosen by checking for as the first directory containing a *conf.d* directory from the list of *topdir* directories:

```
<SSL_MGR_TOPDIR>
./
/etc/ssl-mgr/
```

Where the directories are checked in order and *<SSL_MGR_TOPDIR>* is an environment variable that can be set to take preference.

The config files are located in *topdir/conf.d/* and certificates, key files and so on are saved under *topdir/certs*.

For example if there environment variable is not set and the directory *./conf.d* exists, then it becomes the top level directory. And all configuration files reside under *./conf.d*.

5.10 Log Files

Logs are found in the log directory specified by the global config variable:

```
[globals]
...
logdir = 'xxx'
```

There are 3 kinds of log files in the log directory.

- *<logdir>/ssl-mgr*: General application log
- *<logdir>/cbot*: Application log while interacting with letsencrypt via certbot.
- *<logdir>/letsencrypt/letsencrypt.log.<N>*: Letsencrypt log provided by cerbot.

6.1 Dealing with Possible Problems

Once the configuration files are set up it can be helpful to start with self-signed CA root certificate and a local CA intermediate certificate (signed by that root cert). Use the local intermediate cert to sign your application certificates.

Once this is all working then try using Letsencrypt CA. Upon successful completion the *certs* directory holds all outputs including historical data (older certs and so on).

A subset of the output data is then copied to the production directory. It may also be copied to remote servers if configs request that. After certs are updated and copied then the list of programs to run specified in the *post_copy_cmd* config variable will be run.

If there is a problem for some reason, then updating production will be avoided to minimize any production impact. It is conceivable that after some error conditions, the production cert directory could get out of sync. Or a server reboot while production certs are being updated.

On any subsequent run after experiencing some error condition, When *sslm-mgr* starts, it detects if any production cert files are out of sync. If so, a warning is issued and production cert dirs are updated and servers are restarted.

Manual intervention should not be required but if you need it for some reason, the *dev* option gives ability to force production resync and to restart servers.

This can be done using dev options:

```
sslm-mgr dev --force --certs-to-prod
```

to bring production back in sync. To restart the servers use:

```
sslm-mgr dev --force-server-restarts
```

And you may also want to renew the certs:

```
sslm-mgr -renew
```

and wait the usual 2-3 hours and roll as usual:

```
sslm-mgr -roll
```

6.2 Self Signed CA

The *examples/ca-self* directory has sample how to do this. The CA has a self-signed root certificate (*my-root*) along with an intermediate certificate (*my-int*) which is signed by the root cert. Other certs are then signed by the intermediate certificate.

The 2 public CA certs then need to be added to the linux certificate trust store. To do this copy each cert as below and update the trust store:

```
cp certs/ca/my-root/curr/cert.pem /etc/ca-certificates/trust-source/anchors/my-root.  
↪pem  
cp certs/ca/my-int/curr/cert.pem /etc/ca-certificates/trust-source/anchors/my-int.pem  
update-ca-trust
```

Since browsers do not typically use the system certificate store the same certs will need to be imported into each browser. This can be done manually in the GUI or using *certutil* provided by the *nss* package. Modern browsers typically keep the certificates in a file called *cert9.db* which can be updated using for example something like this (untested):

```
cert9='<path-to>/cert9.db'  
cdir=$(dirname $cert9)  
certutil -A -n "my-int" -t "TC,C,TC" -i xxx/my-int/curr/cert.pem -d sql:$cdir
```

Please see *certutil* man pages for more info.

6.3 Sample Cron File

```
#  
# Renew certs  
# - certs renew (check) every Tue afternoon and roll 3 hours later  
#  
30 14 * * 2 root /usr/bin/sslm-mgr -renew  
30 17 * * 2 root /usr/bin/sslm-mgr -roll  
  
#  
# update dh parms:  
# will update if existing file is older than min age.  
# The default min age is 120 days. Use -a to change min age.  
#  
30 2 5 * 2 root /usr/bin/sslm-dhparm -s /etc/ssl-mgr/prod-certs
```

6.4 Config ca-info.conf

```
[le-dns]      # Used to sign client certs  
    ca_desc = 'Letsencrypt: dns-01 validation'  
    ca_type = 'certbot'  
    ca_validation = 'dns-01'  
  
[le-http]     # Used to sign client certs  
    ca_desc = 'Letsencrypt: http-01 validation'  
    ca_type = 'certbot'  
    ca_validation = 'http-01'  
  
[my-root]    # To sign our own intermediate 'sub' certs  
    ca_desc = 'My Self signed root : EC signs my intermediate certs'  
    ca_type = 'self'  
  
[my-sub]     # Used to sign client certs
```

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```
ca_desc = 'My intermediate : EC signs client certs'
ca_type = 'local'
```

6.5 Config ssl-mgr.conf

```
[globals]
    verb = true
    sslm_auth_hook = '/usr/lib/ssl-mgr/sslm-auth-hook'      # For certbot
    prod_cert_dir = '/etc/ssl-mgr/prod-certs'
    logdir = '/var/log/ssl-mgr/ssl-mgr/Logs'

    clean_keep = 5
    min_roll_mins = 90
    #
    # Letsencrypt profiles: classic, tlsserver, shortlived
    # NB classic is going away.
    #
    preferred_acme_profile = 'tlsserver'

    dns_check_delay = 240
    dns_xtra_ns = ['1.1.1.1', '8.8.8.8', '9.9.9.9', '208.67.222.222']

    post_copy_cmd = [['example.com', '/etc/ssl-mgr/tools/update-permissions'],
                     ['voip.example.com', '/etc/ssl-mgr/tools/voip-checker']]

[renew_info]
    # target times to expiration when to renew
    target_90 = 30.0      # was renew_expire_days in globals section
    target_60 = 20.0
    target_45 = 10.0
    target_10 = 5.0
    target_6 = 2.0
    target_2 = 1.0
    target_1 = 0.5

    # random variability days (0 means no variability)
    rand_adj_90 = 3.0      # was renew_expire_days_spread in globals section
    rand_adj_60 = 0.0
    rand_adj_45 = 0.0
    rand_adj_10 = 0.0
    rand_adj_6 = 0.0
    rand_adj_2 = 0.0
    rand_adj_1 = 0.0

#
# Groups & Services
#
[[groups]]
    active=true
```

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```

    domain='example.net'
    services=['web-ec']

[[groups]]
    active=true
    domain = 'example.com'
    services = ['mail-ec', 'mail-rsa', 'web-ec']

[[groups]]
    active=true
    domain = 'ca'
    services = ['my-root', 'my-sub']

#
# DNS primary provides authorized NS (name servers) and MX hosts of apex_domain
# Must have at least one for acme dns-01
#
[[dns_primary]]
    domain = 'default'
    server = '10.1.2.3'
    port = 11153

[[dns_primary]]
    domain = 'example.com'
    server = '10.1.2.3'
    port = 11153

#
# Servers
#
[dns]
    restart_cmd = '/etc/dns_tools/scripts/resign.sh'
    acme_dir = '/etc/dns_tool/dns/external/staging/zones/include-acme'
    tlsa_dirs = ['/etc/dns_tool/internal/staging/zones/include-tlsa',
                '/etc/dns_tool/external/staging/zones/include-tlsa',
                ]

    # restart trigger when dns (TLSA) zones have changed.
    depends = ['dns']

[smtp]
    servers = ['smtp1.internal.example.com', 'smtp2.internal.example.com']
    # If using sni_maps
    #restart_cmd = ['/usr/bin/postmap -F ldap:/etc/postfix/sni_maps', '/usr/bin/
→postfix reload']
    restart_cmd = '/usr/bin/postfix reload'
    svc_depends = [['example.com', ['mail-rsa', 'mail-ec']]]
    depends = ['dns']

[imap]
    servers = ['imap.internal.example.com']
    restart_cmd = '/usr/bin/systemctl restart dovecot'

```

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```

    svc_depends = [['example.com', ['mail-rsa', 'mail-ec']]]

[web]
    servers = ['web.internal.example.com']
    restart_cmd = '/usr/bin/systemctl reload nginx'
    server_dir = '/srv/http/Sites' # Used for acme http-01 validation
    svc_depends = [['any', ['web-ec']]]

[other]
    # these servers get copies of certs
    servers = ['backup.internal.example.com', 'voip.internal.example.com']
    restart_cmd = ''

```

6.6 Config Service : example.com/mail-ec

```

#
# example.com : mail-ec
#
name = 'Example.com Mail'
group = 'example.com'
service = 'mail-ec'

#signing_ca = 'my-sub'
#signing_ca = 'le-http'
signing_ca = 'le-dns'
renew_expire_days = 30

# Include tls.example.com in zone file to use
# => [[port, proto, usage, selector, match], ...]
dane_tls = [[25, 'tcp', 3, 1, 1]]

[KeyOpts]
    ktype = 'ec'
    ec_algo = 'secp384r1'

[X509]
    # X509Name details
    CN = 'example.com'
    O = 'Example Company'
    OU = 'IT Mail'
    L = ''
    ST = ''
    C = 'US'
    email = 'hostmaster@example.com' # required to register with letsencrypt

    sans = ['example.com', 'smtp.example.com', 'imap.example.com', 'mail.example.com']

```

6.7 Directory tree structure

Directory Structure. By default we only use EC keys, can add RSA if required. We use 'ec' as a label to keep things clear and allow easy way to change to new key types (RSA or other).

Input:

```
conf.d/  
  ssl-mgr.conf  
  ca-info.conf  
  
example.com/  
  mail-ec  
  mail-rsa  
  web-ec  
  
example.net/  
  web-ec  
  
ca/  
  my-root  
  my-sub  
  ...
```

Output - Final Production Certs:

```
prod-certs/  
  example.com/  
    tlsa.example.com  
  
    dh/  
      dh2048.pem  
      dh4096.pem  
      dhparam.pem -> dh4096.pem  
      ...  
    mail-ec/  
      curr/  
        privkey.pem  
        csr.pem  
        chain.pem  
        fullchain.pem  
        cert.pem  
        bundle.pem  
        tlsa.rr  
        info  
    web-ec/  
      ...  
    ...
```

Output - Internal Data

```
certs/  
  example.com/  
    tlsa.example.com
```

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```
mail-ec/
  curr -> db/date1
  next -> db/date2

  db/date1/
    csr.pem
    privkey.pem
    cert.pem
    chain.pem
    fullchain.pem
    bundle.pem
    tlsa.rr
  cb/
    [files used by cerbot]

web-ec/
  curr -> db/date1
  next -> db/date2

  db/date1/
    ...
  cb/
    [files used by cerbot]

.. other services

example.net/
  ...
```

6.8 Installation

Available on

- [Github](#)
- [Archlinux AUR](#)

On Arch you can build using the provided PKGBUILD in the packaging directory or from the AUR. To build manually, clone the repo and :

```
rm -f dist/*
/usr/bin/python -m build --wheel --no-isolation
root_dest="/"
./scripts/do-install $root_dest
```

When running as non-root then set root_dest a user writable directory

6.9 Dependencies

- Run Time :

Package	Comment
python	3.13 or later
dnspython	
cryptography	
dateutil	
lockmgr	Ensures 1 app runs at a time
pyconcurrent	
bash	

- Building Package:

Package	Comment
git	
uv	
uv-build	
rsync	
sphinx	Optional (build) docs:
texlive-latexextra	Optional (build) docs aka texlive tools

6.10 Philosophy

We follow the *live at head commit* philosophy as recommended by Google's Abseil team¹. This means we recommend using the latest commit on git master branch.

6.11 License

Created by Gene C. and licensed under the terms of the MIT license.

- SPDX-License-Identifier: MIT
- SPDX-FileCopyrightText: © 2023-present Gene C <arch@sapience.com>

¹ <https://abseil.io/about/philosophy#upgrade-support>

OLDER CHANGES

Version 6.4 :

- Bug fix where the state machine can lose track of changes that happened.

Version 6.1 :

- New integrity check.

On each run *sslm-mgr* validates that the production directory is up to date and consistent with the current suite of certificates, keys and TLSA files.

If not, it explains what the problem is and suggests possible ways to proceed.

Note that the first run after updating to 6.1 it will automatically re-sync production directory if necessary. No action is required by you.

For more details see [Dealing with Possible Problems](#).

- Keep certs and production certs fully synced.

Includes removing *next* directory from production after the *roll* has happened and *next* is no longer needed. This change allows us to check that production is correctly synchronized. Earlier versions did not remove any files from production, needed or not.

- New dev option *-force-server-restarts*.
- Add ability to specify the top level directory (where configs and outputs are read from / saved to) via environment variable *SSL_MGR_TOPDIR*.
- External programs are run using a local copy of *run_prog()* from the *pyconcurrent* module. You can also install *pyconcurrent* which will ensure the latest version is always used. It is available in [Github pyconcurrnet](#) and [AUR pyconcurrnet](#).

Version 6.0 : Major Changes

- PEP-8, PEP-257 and PEP-484 style and type annotations.
- Major re-write and tidy ups.
- Split up various modules (e.g. certs -> 5 separate crypto modules.)
- Ensure config and command line options are 100% backward compatible.
- Improve 2 config values:

Background: Local CAs have self-signed a root CA certificate which is then used to sign an intermediate CA cert. The intermediate CA is in turn used to sign application certificates.

- *ca-info.conf*: Intermediate local CA entries.

ca_type = “local” is preferred to “self” (NB both work). “self” should still be used for self-signed root CAs where it makes more sense. Intermediate are signed by root and are therefore not self-signed.

- CA service config file for self-signed root certificate:
 - “signing_ca” = “self” is now preferred to an empty string (NB Both work).
- These 2 changes are optional but preferred. No other config file changes.

- Simplify logging code.

Previous Changes:

- Support Letsencrypt alternate root chain.

Set via *ca_preferred_chain* option in *ca-info.conf* file (see example file).

By default LE root cert is *ISRG Root X1* (RSA). Since it is standard to use ECC for certificates, it is preferable to use LE *ISRG Root X2* (ECC) which is smaller and faster since less data is exchanged during TLS handshake.

X2 cert is cross-signed by X1 cert, so any client trusting X1 should trust X2.

Some more info here: [LE Certificates](#): and [Compatibility](#).

- New config option *post_copy_cmd*

For each server getting copies of certs may run this command on machine on which sslm-mgr is running. The command is passed server hostname as an argument. Usage Example: if a server needs a file permission change for an application user to read private key(s). This option is a list of *[server-host, command]* pairs. See [Config ssl-mgr.conf](#)

- X509v3 Extended Key Usage adds “Time Stamping”
- Changed sslm-dhparm to generate RFC-7919 Negotiated Finite Field Diffie-Hellman Ephemeral Parameters files - with the default now set to *ffdhe8192* instead of *ffdhe4096*. User options *-k* overrides the default as usual

NB If you manually update DH files in prod-certs, then push to all servers:

```
sslm-mgr dev -certs-prod
```

NB TLSv1.3 restricts DH key exchange to named groups only.

- In openssl trusted certificates there is ExtraData after the cert which has the trust data. cryptography.x509 will not load this so strip it off. see : <https://github.com/pyca/cryptography/issues/5242>
- Add a working example of self signed web cert in examples/ca-self. Create ca-certs (./make-ca) then generate new web cert signed by that ca. (sslm-mgr -renew; sslm-mgr -roll)
- letsencrypt dns-01 challenge may not always use the apex domain’s authoritative servers or perhaps their (secondary) checks might lag more. We tackle this with the addition of 2 new variables to the top level config:

- *dns-check-delay*.

Given in seconds, this causes a delay before attempting to validate that all authoritative servers have up to date acme challenge dns txt records. Defaults to 240 seconds - this may well need to be made longer. Obviously, this does lead to longer run times - by design.

- *dns_xtra_ns*.

List of nameservers (hostname or ip) which will be checked to have up to date acme challenge dns txt records in addition to each apex domain authoritative nameserver. Default value is:

```
dns_xtra_ns = ['1.1.1.1', '8.8.8.8', '9.9.9.9', '208.67.222.222']
```

- improve the way nameservers are checked for being up to date with acme challenges. First check the primary has all the acme challenge TXT records. Then check all nameservers, including the *xtra_ns* have the same serial as the primary

- While things can take longer than previous versions, testing to date has shown it to be robust and working well with letsencrypt.